

They demanded that Diem lift the ban on religious flags, compensate the families of the victims, and punish the officials responsible for the killings. Diem claimed instead that the deaths had been caused by a Viet Cong agent throwing a hand grenade into the crowd, and rejected the Buddhists' demands even as demonstrations in Hue against the regime became an almost daily occurrence. Diem imposed martial law on Hue and instituted a dusk-to-dawn curfew.

When news of the initial incident at Hue reached Washington, Dean Rusk, the secretary of state, was quick to respond. In a telegram to the US embassy in Saigon, he told Ambassador Nolting to urge Diem "to take no repressive measures against Buddhists" and to "make ... gestures toward restoration of order and amity." Nolting did his best, but to little avail. Diem grudgingly assured him that the repression would cease, but it soon became clear that he had no intention of keeping his word. He and his brother, Nhu, stalled for time, hoping to ride out the crisis.



Addressing the crowd

A Buddhist leader speaks from atop a car on June 16, 1963. Buddhists protested in different ways: some made speeches, others mutilated themselves or died by suicide.